



when he remained unbeaten, finishing 1.5 points ahead of the second-placed Ding. Later, Ding got the chance to play the World title after Carlsen decided not to defend his crown.

So Nepomniachtchi clearly knows a thing or two about winning the Candidates tournament. Expect him to mount a strong challenge for his third straight Candidates title.

The Iranian-born French prodigy Alireza Firouzja may not have been as experienced or as successful as Nepomniachtchi at the Candidates, but he is a young exciting talent.

Carlsen had in fact said that he would be defending his World title only if Firouzja had emerged as the Candidate in 2022.

The teenager, however, could only finish sixth in a field of eight in that Candidates tournament. The World No. 6 will want to put up a better performance this time

Defending champion: Expect Ian Nepomniachtchi to mount a strong challenge for his third straight Candidates title. LENNART OOTES

around.

The women's section looks more open. Humpy certainly has chances, while her younger compatriot Vaishali has shown remarkable improvement of late.

The reigning Candidates champion Lei Tingjie (right), who lost to compatriot Ju Wenjun in the World championship last year, is one of the main contenders. The other Chinese in the field, Tan Zhongyi, is a former World champion.

Russia's Aleksandra Goryachkina is the highest ranked female player in Toronto, with a rating of 2553.

The other Russian, Kateryna Lagno, and Ukraine's Anna Muzychuk are experienced campaigners, too.



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